

HZ-6 Sample Line Field Mission Report

UNITED STATES DEPARTMENT OF THE INTERIOR
BUREAU OF ANTARCTIC SURVEY
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CONFIDENTIAL / BAS INTERNAL / INTERAGENCY
FIELD SURVEY REPORT

Report No.: BAS-FLD-1961-HZ6-014
Incident Cross-Reference: BAS-INC-1961-HZ6-003
Photographic Reference: BAS-PHOTO-1961-HZ6-R06
Subject: HZ-6 Sample Line Field Mission and Subsequent Personnel Loss
Date of Operation: 18-19 November 1961
Initial Field Notes Filed: 20 November 1961
Photographic Addendum Entered: 14 December 1961
Station: Horizon Station
Copy: 2 of 5

1. Purpose

This file was assembled at the direction of the Horizon Station chief. It covers the HZ-6 Sample Line party, equipment, communications, photographic material, and losses. Use is limited to Bureau review, Navy liaison review, and revision of station field procedure. It is not cleared for public release.

The public line remains the same: a biological sampling party failed to return from low-forest operations; one member was recovered with cold exposure and route disorientation; the remaining members were not recovered. The station copy carries additional entries for field incident, unidentified animal contact, sealed photographic evidence, and failure of the survivor to give a stable form description.

2. Location and Mission Summary

The mission area lies within the White Abyss twilight needlewood layer, approximately 8.7 miles southeast of Horizon Station, along the HZ-6 survey grid. The route extends from the HZ-6A vehicle turn point to the HZ-6C low-forest sample marker. HZ-6A is reachable by M29C Weasel. HZ-6B through HZ-6C must be traversed on foot through low black needlewood, shallow frost cover, wet black soil patches, and raised root-plate ground.

The party was sent out as a routine ecological sampling detail, with survey maintenance added to the same trip. The dispatch sheet listed the following:

1. Photograph black needlewood root plates and surface frost between HZ-6A and HZ-6C.
2. Recover the air-filter cartridge at HZ-6C.
3. Collect white shell fragments and soil near low drag marks.
4. Confirm reported "silent bird" activity.
5. Refresh return-route markers on the southeast sample line.
6. Test voice quality through the HZ-6A cable relay box.

3. Personnel

Name	Duty	Status	Notes
Lt. Howard P. Rusk	Field leader	Deceased, body not recovered	U.S. Navy attachment; route and forward security; carried M1 carbine

Name	Duty	Status	Notes
Dr. Helen M. Klein	Biologist	Missing	Root-plate, shell-fragment, filter, and soil sampling
Sgt. Daniel Keene	Radio operator	Missing	AN/PRC-10 operation and HZ-6A relay contact
Thomas E. Mallory	Photographer	Survived	BAS civilian photographic technician; left arm fracture, early hypothermia, memory discontinuity
PO2 Samuel R. Vance	Rear guard	Missing	U.S. Navy attachment; rear security; carried second M1 carbine

The normal walking order was Rusk first, Keene second, Klein third, Mallory fourth, and Vance fifth. Mallory's normal field position placed three members ahead of his camera and the rear guard behind him or outside the frame. Deviation from this order occurred only at sample stops and after the incident began.

4. Equipment and Photographic Apparatus

The party carried cold-weather clothing, one AN/PRC-10 portable radio, a spare battery pack, two electric hand lamps, one acetylene lamp, a Brunton compass, route board, wax-sealed HZ-6 field map, twelve numbered route flags, sample tins, glass sample bottles, soil sampler, gas detection tubes, two days of C-rations, medical kit, one signal pistol, and six red signal cartridges. One M29C Weasel was parked at HZ-6A and did not enter the low-forest section.

Mallory carried two cameras. A Rolleiflex 3.5E loaded with Kodak Plus-X Pan 120 roll film was assigned to static samples and root-plate records. A Nikon F 35mm single-lens reflex camera loaded with Kodak Tri-X Pan ASA 400 was assigned to movement, personnel, and emergency documentation. The Nikon kit included a Nikkor-S 50mm f/1.4 lens and a Nikkor-Q 135mm f/3.5 lens. Additional photographic equipment included a Weston Master III exposure meter, a Graflex flash bracket, twenty-four Sylvania M3 flashbulbs, spare film, lens cloth, waxed film bags, and a field notebook.

5. Chronology

0738 The party departed Horizon Station through East Door No. 2 by M29C Weasel and proceeded along the ventilation road toward HZ-6A.

0925 The party arrived at HZ-6A. The Weasel was parked outside the marker post. Keene connected to the HZ-6A cable relay box. Mallory exposed six Rolleiflex frames of root plates and surface frost.

1110 Klein collected white shell fragments north of the sample line. Gas readings were within normal limits.

1240 Lunch halt. Keene reported repeated pecking sounds from the tree line. The sound was provisionally entered as "silent bird" activity. Mallory exposed two Nikon F frames of normal movement.

1518 The party reached HZ-6C. Klein removed the air-filter cartridge and placed it in the sample case. Field notes mention resin odor, wet bark, and unusual low drag marks near the marker.

1712 Diffuse ice-ceiling light and sample-line marker light decreased faster than expected. Rusk ordered return to HZ-6A by the same route.

1819 Keene reported that the pecking sounds had stopped. Mallory later stated this was the first time he raised the camera without being instructed to do so.

1822 First unscheduled flash exposure. Mallory believed this frame showed Lt. Rusk turning toward the tree line.

1824-1828 Keene attempted to report return delay through the HZ-6A relay. Horizon Station received broken voice only: "HZ-6 party is checking moving source east of route." This sentence is not considered a formal distress call or completed field assessment.

1829 Presumed unidentified animal contact. During first interview Mallory stated that the object came out "against the roots." His continuous memory fails between the object raising its forward portion and the party scattering.

1831-1836 Party retreat and dispersal. Film sequence indicates that Mallory continued to trip the Nikon F shutter after running, falling, or being struck. Flash did not fire on every exposure. Vance's position is not recorded in a complete or stable frame.

1840 The party separated before reaching HZ-6A. Klein, Keene, and Vance were lost from visual contact. Rusk may have fired one signal cartridge. Firing of either M1 carbine is unconfirmed.

1905 Mallory reached shallow water near a Black Lake tributary. He recalled water, broken flashbulbs inside his glove, and repeatedly working the film-advance lever. He could not explain why he had left the sample line.

19 November 1961, 0218 A rescue party found Mallory approximately 1.4 miles west of the planned return route. The Nikon F remained on his neck strap and had been advanced to the end of the roll. The Rolleiflex was missing.

0325 Mallory was returned to Horizon Station.

0410 The Nikon F and exposed roll were received jointly by a BAS archivist and Navy guard. Mallory did not participate in development.

6. Communications and Rescue

The HZ-6 low-forest section does not provide reliable direct radio contact with Horizon Station. The party depended on the HZ-6A cable relay box. Broken voice received between 1824 and 1828 is the final confirmed station contact. No complete distress call, casualty report, or return confirmation was received.

The rescue party began search operations from HZ-6A on the night of 18 November. The M29C Weasel remained parked at the vehicle point. Its engine was cold and there were no signs of post-incident operation or collision. Mallory's recovery position indicates that he moved away from the sample line toward the Black Lake tributary after the incident, but he could not account for this movement.

7. Photographic Material

The Rolleiflex roll exposed during the early sample work was not recovered. The 35mm roll recovered from the Nikon F was assigned the file number HZ-6/R06. It was developed three weeks later in the McMurdo Bay B imaging room under Bureau supervision.

Thirty-seven frames were recovered. Six frames are available for ordinary review. Fourteen frames are restricted or held for technical re-examination. Seventeen frames are unusable, repeated, severely motion-blurred, or black. Frame 37 is an incomplete tail frame and is not treated as independent evidence.

Restricted frames reportedly show Rusk turning toward the tree line; a low dark silhouette between root plates; Klein falling or crouching; Vance only as a shoulder, weapon strap, or boot fragment at the margin; wet reflective surfaces; diagonal black smears; and loss of outline caused by flash overexposure. No frame provides a complete animal form.

Mallory was not permitted to view the developed material. The medical reason given was prevention of agitation and confused memory reconstruction. The internal note is more direct: "Do not permit subject to reconstruct memory from restricted photographic sequence."

8. Contact Object

The contact object was assigned the temporary designation HZ6-CO-01 during review. This designation is used only to link negatives, tracks, injuries, and site traces. It is not a species name.

The records support only this much: unidentified large animal contact in the low-forest section. The object moved close to the ground, with a long back, high shoulders, and forelimbs that appeared too long under flash. It passed through the black needlewood root plates without the hesitation expected from a party member or a lost animal. The recovered negatives show blurred silhouettes and partial wet reflective edges. They do not show a head, face, or complete side profile.

Mallory acknowledged seeing the contact object, but he could not connect seeing it, being attacked, photographing, and fleeing into one continuous memory. He did not use the word "face" in any recorded description. His most stable statement was: "It was waiting in the woods. It was not hiding."

9. Mallory interview extract

The following text is copied from BAS-PERS-1961-HZ6-MAL-01, first contact record, Horizon Station infirmary. Time of record: 0520 to 0543, 19 November 1961. Mallory had been warmed and his left arm had been splinted. Recorder's note: this portion was taken before formal sedation. Subject showed shivering, pauses, and repetition. Medical commands and unrelated initials have been omitted.

Q. Do you know where you are?
A. The station. Infirmary. Do not open the camera back. I have not rewound it.

Q. Which camera?
A. The Nikon. The Rollei is gone. I had it after the filter point, or I thought I still had it. I do not have it now.

Q. When was the last ordered photograph?
A. After noon. Walking frames. Rusk was ahead, Keene had the radio, Klein was behind them. Vance should have been behind me.

Q. What happened on the return?
A. The light went flat. Not dark. Flat. Rusk said we were going back. Keene was still saying the knocking had stopped.

Q. What did you see?
A. The roots moved first. Not the trees. The line between the roots moved. That sounds wrong, but that is what I saw.

Q. Where did the object appear?
A. Against the roots. Not from behind the trees. Do not write behind the trees. It was low. Too low for a man walking.

Q. Did it resemble a person?
A. No. There was a part that looked like it braced on a root, maybe. Or stepped on it. Do not write that as a hand. I did not see a hand.

Q. Did you continue to photograph?
A. I think so. One flash went very white. After that some did not fire. I kept thumbing the advance. It stuck once. I forced it through.

Q. Where were the others?
A. Rusk was forward. Keene had the radio. Klein went down, or crouched. Vance should have been behind me. I do not remember him. That is wrong.

Q. Why did you leave the sample line?
A. I do not know. That part is gone. I remember under the trees, then water. I was still working the advance, but the roll may have been done.

Q. Anything else?
A. It was waiting in the woods. It was not hiding.

Recorder's note: subject twice requested that "braced on a root" not be recorded as "hand." When asked to describe the head or face, subject closed his eyes for approximately twenty seconds and answered, "I do not have that part." The medical officer ended questioning at 0545.

10. Personnel and Material Disposition

Lt. Rusk is listed as deceased, body not recovered. Dr. Klein, Sgt. Keene, and PO2 Vance are listed as missing. Mallory was removed from Horizon Station on 4 December 1961. Further medical observation records are sealed separately.

The Rolleiflex camera, Klein's sample case, two M1 carbines, part of the soil collection, and the HZ-6C filter cartridge were not recovered. The filter cartridge had been removed from its marker but was not returned to the station. The M29C Weasel was towed back to Horizon Station on the morning of 19 November without visible collision damage.

11. Findings and Recommendations

1. Suspend non-essential operations between HZ-6B and HZ-6C until route, communication, and lighting procedures are reviewed.
2. Do not authorize low-forest sample-line work with fewer than five personnel. Forward and rear security positions are required.
3. Do not permit movement beyond HZ-6A after 1600 local without approval from both the station chief and Navy liaison office.
4. Transfer all exposed photographic material to BAS Photographic Analysis under sealed custody. Surviving personnel are not to view restricted image sequences.
5. Do not register HZ6-CO-01 as a species. Continue use of the temporary contact-object designation in Bureau files.
6. Maintain the external explanation of cold exposure, route deviation, and field communications failure. Preserve internal references to unidentified animal contact and survivor morphological memory discontinuity.

Filed by: BAS Horizon Station Field Office

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